CORE FALSE BELIEF #5 · MY STRENGTH

“I am powerless.”

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Where it often comes from

People often learn powerlessness in situations where they truly had no control: growing up with an abusive or addicted parent, being bullied, living through poverty or illness, or being trapped in a controlling relationship. The lesson “nothing I do makes a difference” can follow a person into adulthood, even after the situation has changed and real choices have returned.

What Scripture teaches

The Bible is honest that we are limited and cannot save ourselves. But it never leaves God’s people helpless. God gives power to the faint and strength to the weak. Paul said he could do all things through Christ who strengthens him. God has not given us a spirit of fear, but of power, love, and self-control. In Christ we are not powerless; we are dependent on a powerful God who works within us. Some things are outside our control, but we are never without God’s help or without some choice.

> *“He gives power to the faint and increases the strength of the weak. Even youths grow tired and weary, and young men stumble and fall. But those who wait upon the LORD will renew their strength; they will mount up with wings like eagles; they will run and not grow weary, they will walk and not faint”* (Isaiah 40:29–31).

Also see

> “I can do all things through Christ who gives me strength” (Philippians 4:13).

> “For God has not given us a spirit of fear, but of power, love, and self-control” (2 Timothy 1:7).

> “Now to Him who is able to do immeasurably more than all we ask or imagine, according to His power that is at work within us” (Ephesians 3:20).

> “Have I not commanded you to be strong and courageous? Do not be afraid; do not be discouraged, for the LORD your God is with you wherever you go” (Joshua 1:9).

Common self-statements

- Nothing I do makes a difference.
- Things just happen to me.
- I have no say in my own life.
- Other people control everything.
- I can’t change anything.
- Why bother trying?

Common logical errors

- Overgeneralization: Believing that because I was powerless once, I am powerless in everything.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Thinking that if I cannot control everything, I control nothing.
- Fortune telling: Predicting that my efforts will not matter before I try.
- Discounting the positive: Overlooking the choices I do make every day.

Challenging questions

- When did I first feel truly powerless, and is that situation still true today?
- What choices do I have right now, even small ones?
- What is in my control, and what is not?
- What does God say He gives to the weak?
- When have I made a difference, even in a small way?
- Who could help me with what I cannot do alone?

Truth summary

> There are things I cannot control, and there were times I truly had no power. But I am not powerless now. God gives strength to the weak, and in Christ I can take the steps in front of me. I have choices, and I have a God who works within me.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Strength
- Weakness
- God, All Powerful
- Help
- Fear

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Weak/Tired
- Anxiety/Worry/Fear

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Our God — Chris Tomlin
God's greatness challenges helplessness before evil or hardship.

Same Power — Jeremy Camp
God's power challenges the belief that evil or fear has the final authority.

Whom Shall I Fear — Chris Tomlin
God's presence provides courage without requiring a life free of difficulty.

Victory in Jesus — Joy Gardner, Cynthia Clawson, Mike Allen and Reggie Smith
This classic gospel hymn celebrates Christ's rescue and the hope of life with Him.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I am powerless"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I am powerless." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Is the situation that made me powerless still true?
- ☐ What choices do I have right now?
- ☐ What is in my control?
- ☐ What does God give to the weak?
- ☐ When have I made a difference?
- ☐ Who could help me?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God gives strength to the weary.
- ☐ I can do all things through Christ.
- ☐ God gave me power, love, and self-control.
- ☐ I always have some choice.
- ☐ What happened then is not the same as now.
- ☐ I can ask for help and still be strong.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Isaiah 40:29–31
  "He gives power to the faint and increases the strength of the weak. Even youths grow tired and weary, and young men stumble and fall. But those who wait upon the LORD will renew their strength; they will mount up with wings like eagles; they will run and not grow weary, they will walk and not faint."
- ☐ Philippians 4:13
  "I can do all things through Christ who gives me strength."
- ☐ 2 Timothy 1:7
  "For God has not given us a spirit of fear, but of power, love, and self-control."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Choices I made today: Each evening, list three choices you made today, however small, and note what difference each one made.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Isaiah 40:29–31 becomes: "Karen can write: "God gives power to the faint. When I am weak, I can wait on Him and find new strength.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Strength" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If this belief comes with hopelessness or thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. You do not have to carry this alone.

- [ ] Sort what you can and cannot control. Draw two columns. List what worries you, then place each item under "In my control" or "Not in my control." Pray over the second; act on the first.
- [ ] Take one action. Pick one item in your control and take one small step on it this week.
- [ ] Use your voice once. State one honest preference or need to someone this week, such as where to eat or what you need.
- [ ] Get the right help. If someone is controlling or harming you, talk privately with a counselor, pastor, or trusted person about safe next steps.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I am powerless": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A choice I made
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I am powerless.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have felt helpless for so long. Thank You that You give strength to the weary and power to the weak. Show me the choices I have, give me courage to take them, and help me rest in You for what I cannot control. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.